

M-COMM

Reference question: (2023)

Please **choose one of the two** topics given below and relate it to your life experience. The two assignment topics are: **Team Communication and Intercultural Communication**.

If you choose Team Communication as your topic, you would be required to narrate and analyse a team-related experience (it could be, for instance, a challenging situation, a successful completion of task etc). You are expected to analyse it using relevant concepts to demonstrate your communication-related learnings. If you choose intercultural communication, you are expected to share an intercultural experience, analyse it and apply relevant concepts to demonstrate communication-related learnings.

This assignment has two parts:

Part 1 - Summary: Provide a summary of your experience in minimum of 400 words. Include all relevant information, including the overall context and your communication goals.

Part 2 - Analysis: Provide your analysis of the specific instance by applying relevant theoretical concepts. This portion of your writing should be minimum 800 words.

Other Guidelines:

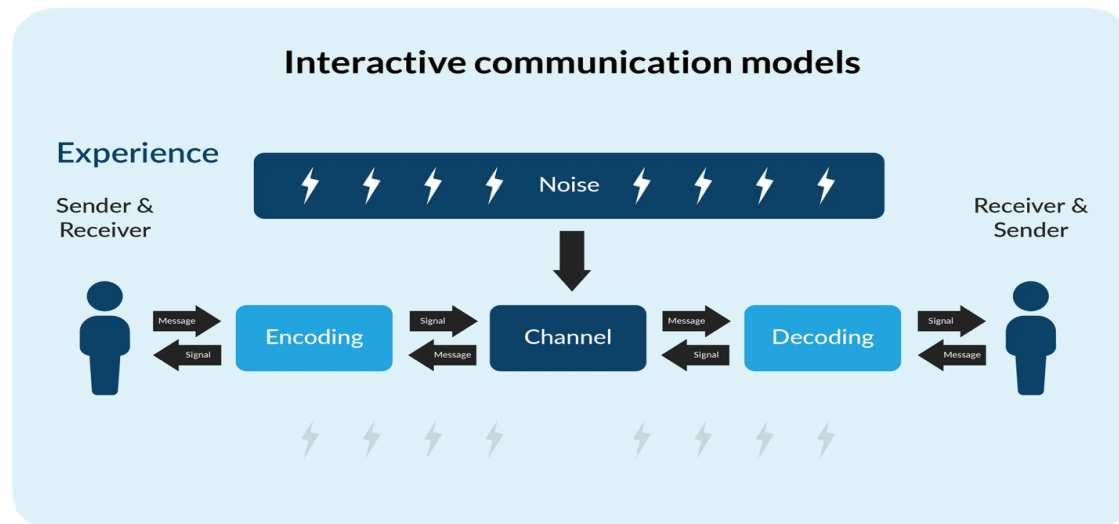
1. This is an open book exam. However, do not copy any explanation or definition directly from the textbook or any other reading material. This will be counted as plagiarism.
2. You cannot use your laptops / phones / tablets.
3. You have 90 minutes to complete your answer.
4. Total word count: Minimum word count: 1200

Course outline

1. **Core Concepts of Communication** — Sessions 1–2
 2. **Verbal Communication** — Session 3
 3. **Non-Verbal Communication** — Session 4
 4. **Listening** — Session 5
 5. **Giving & Receiving Feedback** — Session 6
 6. **Communicating Within Teams** — Session 7
 7. **Difficult Communication** — Session 8
 8. **Persuasive Communication** — Session 9
 9. **Culture & Communication** — Session 10
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Core Concepts of Communication- Session 1+2

Interactive Communication Process Model



Key Components:

- **Source/Sender:** Person initiating the communication
- **Encoding:** Converting an idea into a communicative form
- **Message:** Information being communicated
- **Receiver:** Person receiving the message
- **Decoding:** Interpreting the message
- **Feedback:** Response to the communication
- **Shared Meaning:** Meaning developed between the communicators
- **Context:** Situation in which communication occurs
- **Culture:** Cultural background influencing communication
- **Noise:** Factors interfering with communication

Example: During a presentation, a manager explains a new strategy. Employees' questions and reactions provide feedback, which may cause the manager to clarify or change the explanation.

Noise in Communication- Noise refers to factors that interfere with the communication process.

1. **External Noise-** Interference arising from the physical environment. **Example:** Construction noise makes it difficult for employees to hear a manager during a meeting.
2. **Physiological Noise-** Interference arising from the physical condition of the communicator or receiver. **Example:** An employee who is extremely tired may have difficulty concentrating during a presentation.

3. **Psychological Noise**- Interference arising from thoughts, emotions, attitudes or mental processes. **Example:** An employee who is already upset with their manager may interpret a neutral comment as criticism.

Principles of Communication

1. **Communicators Create Meaning Through Interaction**- Meaning is created through interaction between communicators. Both parties mutually influence each other during communication. **Example:** A manager notices that an employee looks confused after an explanation and changes the explanation accordingly.
2. **Communication Can Be Intentional and Unintentional**
3. **Communication Is Largely Irreversible**

Content Dimension and Relational Dimension

Content Dimension- Refers to **what is being communicated** — the literal or informational component of the message.

Relational Dimension- Refers to **what the communication communicates about the relationship** between the people involved, including attitudes, respect, status, power or emotional orientation.

Example: "You forgot to check your messages."

Content: The person did not check their messages & **Relational meaning:** Depending on tone and context, it could communicate concern, frustration, criticism or authority.

Interpretive Model of Communication- The Interpretive Model challenges the traditional view that communication is primarily about the sender's words and body language. It emphasizes the receiver's interpretation in creating meaning.

Communication: "This is a good idea."

Interpretation 1: "The speaker is interested in my work."/ **Interpretation 2:** "These words are meaningless."

Interpretive Nature of Communication- "We don't receive meaning, we create meaning," based on our perceptions, assumptions and context.

Example: If a professor says "Interesting" after a student's answer, the student could interpret it as praise, curiosity, skepticism or dismissal depending on the situation.

Understanding the Audience

Effective communication is not only about: "**What do I want to say?**" It is also about: "**How is the other person likely to understand what I am saying?**"

Assumptions and Behaviour

We can observe another person's behaviour but cannot directly observe the assumptions underlying that behaviour. **People often interpret behaviour based on their own assumptions.** Different assumptions about the same behaviour can lead to communication breakdown.

Example:

Observed behaviour: An employee remains silent during a meeting.

Manager's assumption: "The employee is not prepared."

Possible reality: The employee may actually feel uncomfortable speaking because senior members keep interrupting.

Effective communication requires sufficient shared assumptions or common ground between communicators.

Example: A manager tells an employee to make a presentation "more strategic." If both have different interpretations of "strategic," the message may be understood differently from what the manager intended.

Levels of Perception

"I think my idea is good."- **My perception**- How I perceive a situation.

↓

"I think you don't like my idea."- **My perception of your perception**- How I think you perceive the situation.

↓

"I think you know that I think you don't like my idea."- **My perception of your perception of my perception**- How I think you perceive my own perception.

Communication can become complicated because people respond not only to what others actually say or do, but also to what they **think others think**.

Communication Competence- Communication competence refers to the ability to communicate effectively by understanding the audience and adapting communication appropriately.

1. Understanding the Audience

2. Adaptability- Adaptation may involve:

- Language
- Tone
- Level of detail
- Examples
- Pace
- Communication medium

3. Empathy / Perspective Taking

4. Self-Monitoring

Verbal Communication- Session 2

Verbal communication goes beyond simply "speaking clearly." It focuses on how **word choice, framing and social structures influence what becomes visible, whose perspective is treated as legitimate, and how communication is received.**

1. Social Construction of Reality

Communication does not take place in a social vacuum. The **meanings attached to words and categories are shaped by the social context in which communication occurs.**

- Race
- Gender Identity
- Sexual Orientation
- **Intersectionality**

Example: The way a person's professional identity is perceived may be influenced not only by their actual qualifications but also by socially constructed expectations associated with gender, class, language or other identities.

2. Framing- Different ways of describing the same event can direct attention toward different interpretations.

People in floodwaters who obtained food from a grocery store:

Caption 1: "Two residents waded through chest-deep water after finding bread and soda from a local grocery store..."

Caption 2: "A young man walks through chest deep flood water after looting a grocery store in New Orleans..."

The event is presented differently through the choice of "**finding**" versus "**looting**."

3. Words Activate Interpretation

Compare: "**Tax relief**" vs. "**Tax cut**"

Both refer to a reduction in taxes, but the different wording can activate different associations or ways of understanding the policy.

The choice of a particular word can bring certain associations, assumptions and interpretations to the foreground.

4. Form, Frame and Floor

3 underlying mechanisms of verbal communication:

FORM- Form concerns the **structure and organisation of an argument**.

Example: Problem → Analysis → Options → Recommendation rather than presenting disconnected information.

FRAME- Frame concerns the way **wording directs attention and shapes interpretation**.

Example: Calling an employee's mistake a "**learning opportunity**" frames the situation differently from calling it a "**failure**."

FLOOR- Floor concerns **participation and legitimacy in communication**- who gets an opportunity to speak and whose contribution is allowed to continue. **Who can enter, continue, redirect or challenge?**

Example: In a meeting, a junior employee may technically be allowed to speak, but if senior members repeatedly interrupt them, they do not have the same effective access to the floor.

5. Words can carry **additional assumptions and associations beyond their literal dictionary meaning**.

6. **Gendered Language**

Language may not serve all speakers equally when different groups have not contributed equally to the **formulation** of that language.

Examples:

- Mankind
- Manmade
- Manpower
- Manhandle

Women are often linguistically defined through their **relationship** to men, while men have more varied and autonomous linguistic status.

Key Idea- Language can encode assumptions about **identity, relationships and social status.**- **Mr XYZ vs Mrs XYZ / Miss XYZ** The terminology can introduce information about marital status for women that is not equivalently required for men.

8. Framing: Word Choices Do More Than Name Things

Word choices can **activate interpretations** rather than simply naming things.

When analysing a particular word or description, ask:

- **What does the term make immediately visible?**- What aspect of the situation receives attention?
- **What does it place in the background?**- What becomes less noticeable or disappears from attention?
- **Who appears to act?**- Does the wording make one person/group appear to be the actor?
- **Who benefits, suffers or disappears?**- Who is represented as gaining or experiencing consequences?
- **What alternative would redistribute attention?**- Could another choice of words highlight a different aspect of the situation?

9. Who Gets Legitimacy on the Floor?- "Whose position, opinion, or place is normalised, and who has to work (fight) for it?"

Having the formal opportunity to speak is not necessarily the same as having a legitimate **voice**. A person's contribution may be treated differently depending on their social or organisational position.

10. Who Gets the Floor?

- **Invitation-** Is the person expected, permitted or actively invited to contribute?
Example: A junior team member may technically be allowed to speak but may never be actively invited to
- **Entry-** Can the person secure a turn without being ignored, spoken over or required to display unusual assertiveness? **Example:** An employee repeatedly tries to enter a conversation but is interrupted by senior colleagues.
- **Continuity-** Can the person complete their point, or must they repeatedly repair interruptions and topic shifts? **Example:** A team member begins explaining an idea but is interrupted several times and never gets to complete the argument.
- **Audibility Example:** A person's contribution may be technically clear but receive less attention if their accent or communication style is not institutionally valued.
- **Credibility-** Is the speaker treated as knowledgeable before having to provide extraordinary proof of competence or moral worth?
- **Uptake-** Do others respond to the actual claim, preserve attribution and carry it into minutes, policy or action?
- **Negative Consequences-** When someone attempts to speak or challenge existing positions, the consequences of speaking are not necessarily equal for everyone.

11. Why Are Some Views Accepted More Than Others?

- **Formal Authority**
- **Control of Resources**
- **Seniority and Kinship**- family relationships.
- Gendered Expectations
- Caste and Class Location
- Language Capital- The value attached to particular languages, accents, registers or forms of linguistic competence.
- Employment Position
- Interactional Style- The way someone participates in conversations.
- Coalition and Repetition- Support from others and repeated articulation of a position.
- Medium and Procedure- The communication channel and rules governing participation.

Non-Verbal Communication- Session 3

1. What is Non-Verbal Communication?

It includes body movement, facial expressions, posture, eye contact, physical appearance, space, touch, voice characteristics and environmental cues.

Non-verbal communication accompanies verbal communication and can:

- **reinforce what is being said**,
- **add** meaning,
- **contradict words**,
- **regulate** interaction,
- **substitute for words**.

Example: A manager says, "I'm listening," while continuously looking at their laptop. The words communicate attention, but the non-verbal behaviour may communicate the opposite.

2. Why Non-Verbal Communication Matters

Non-verbal communication is important because a significant amount of meaning in interpersonal interaction is communicated through **non-verbal rather than verbal cues**.

- attitudes,
- emotions,
- interest,
- comfort/discomfort,

However, non-verbal cues **must be interpreted in context** rather than treated as automatic proof of a particular feeling or intention.

Example: Crossed arms could indicate defensiveness, but could equally reflect comfort, temperature or habit. Context is essential.

3. Non-Verbal Categories

The reading broadly identifies three categories:

3.1 Sign Language- Gestures, **Example:** A thumbs-up can communicate approval without words.

3.2 Action Language- Movements that are not exclusively intended as communication but can nevertheless communicate, **Example:** Walking away from a meeting can signal that a person is leaving the interaction.

3.3 Object Language- Physical objects/material surroundings that communicate something, **Example:** Clothing, jewellery, office décor or possessions can communicate aspects of identity,

4. The Non-Verbal Process

Three-step interpretive process:

1. **Cue-** We first observe a non-verbal signal. **Example:** A normally cheerful colleague arrives looking withdrawn.
2. **Expectation-** We compare the cue against what we normally expect from that person. **Example:** "This is unusual behaviour for her."
3. **Inference-** We draw a conclusion about what the behaviour might mean. **Example:** "Something may be bothering her."

People can make incorrect inferences from non-verbal behaviour because they may not know the underlying situation.

5. Functions of Non-Verbal Communication

5.1 Accenting- Non-verbal behaviour **emphasises** or highlights part of a verbal message. **Example:** A manager says, "This deadline is extremely important," while strongly stressing the words and using an emphatic gesture.

5.2 Complementing- Non-verbal communication **adds to or supports** the verbal message. **Example:** A manager says "Well done" while smiling and nodding.

5.3 Contradicting- Non-verbal behaviour communicates something different from the verbal message. **Example:** Employee: "I'm completely comfortable with the decision." Employee simultaneously appears visibly tense and avoids eye contact.

5.4 Regulating- Non-verbal signals help **manage the flow of conversation**. **Example:** A person raises a hand to indicate they want to speak, or maintains eye contact to signal that they have not finished.

5.5 Repeating- Non-verbal communication **repeats the verbal message**. **Example:** Someone says "The room is that way" while pointing in that direction.

5.6 Substituting- A non-verbal cue **replaces words altogether**. **Example:** A thumbs-up substitutes for saying "Yes" or "Good."

6. Principles of Non-Verbal Communication

The reading identifies several broad principles.

Principle 1: Context Is Essential

Principle 2: Non-Verbal Behaviour Occurs Simultaneously

People often produce several non-verbal signals at the same time. Therefore, interpretation should consider the **overall pattern**, not one isolated cue.

Principle 3: All Behaviour Communicates

Because behaviour is observable, even apparently meaningless behaviour can carry communicative value.

Example: Looking at the clock repeatedly during a meeting can communicate impatience or a desire to leave.

Principle 4: Non-Verbal Behaviour Can Be Governed by Rules

People learn culturally and socially appropriate rules regarding:

- gestures,
- eye contact,
- touch,
- space,
- clothing,
- vocal behaviour.

Example: The amount of eye contact considered appropriate in one culture may be perceived differently in another.

Principle 5: Non-Verbal Behaviour Is Not Necessarily Universal

Same cue ≠ Same meaning everywhere, Example: Norms regarding eye contact, personal distance and touching differ across cultures.

Principle 6: Non-Verbal Behaviour Is Multidimensional- Non-verbal communication includes many dimensions rather than one unified category. (Covered point 7 onwards)

7. Movement/Kinesics

Kinesics = the study of human movement as communication.

It includes:

- gestures,
- posture,
- facial expressions,

- body movement.

7.1 Emblems- Gestures that have a relatively specific, recognised meaning. **Example:** Thumbs-up = approval.

7.2 Illustrators- Gestures that accompany and illustrate verbal communication.

Example: Using your hands to show the size of something while describing it.

7.3 Affect Displays- Behaviours that communicate **emotional states**. **Example:** A smile communicating happiness.

7.4 Regulators- Movements that help regulate interaction. **Example:** Nodding to encourage someone to continue speaking.

7.5 Adaptors- Movements used to adapt to a situation or manage internal states. **Example:** Fidgeting with a pen when nervous.

8. Eye Contact

It can influence perceptions of:

- attention,
- confidence,
- interest,
- involvement,
- dominance,
- credibility.

However, interpretation **depends on culture and context.**

9. Physical Appearance

It can influence perceptions of:

- professionalism,
- competence,
- status,
- identity,
- organisational fit.

10. Artifacts

Artifacts are objects that communicate meaning.

Example: The design and contents of a manager's office may communicate hierarchy or accessibility.

11. Touch / Haptics= communication through physical touch.

Examples:

- handshake,
- pat on the back,
- handshake during introduction.

Touch can communicate:

- warmth,
- support,
- dominance,
- familiarity,
- respect.

But touch is **highly dependent on context, culture, relationship and professional boundaries**.

Example: A handshake may be appropriate during a formal business introduction, while another form of physical contact may not be appropriate.

12. Paralanguage

Paralanguage refers to **how something is said rather than the words themselves**.

It includes:

- pitch,
- rate/speed,
- volume,
- tone,
- vocal quality,
- pauses.

13. **Space / Proxemics- Proxemics** = the study of how people use **physical space and interpersonal distance** in communication.

13.1 Intimate Zone- Approximately **0–18 inches**. Used for very close relationships and situations involving physical intimacy.

13.2 Personal Zone- Approximately **18 inches–4 feet**. Typical of interactions with friends, acquaintances and people with whom we have some familiarity.

13.3 Social Zone- Approximately **4–12 feet**. Common in professional and social interactions.

13.4 Public Zone- Approximately **12 feet and beyond**. Typical of public speaking and large-group communication.

14. Spatial Differences Across People and Cultures

Personal-space expectations differ according to:

- culture,
- gender,
- situation,
- relationship,
- status,
- physical environment.

The readings note that people from different cultures may have different expectations regarding interpersonal distance.

15. Strategic Use of Space

Office design, seating arrangements and physical distance can communicate:

- power,
- authority,
- equality,
- openness,
- hierarchy.

Example: A large executive desk positioned separately from employees can create a stronger perception of hierarchy/ A round table with equal seating can communicate greater equality and openness.

16. Time / Chronemics

Chronemics = the study of how **time communicates meaning**. Time-related cues include:

- punctuality,
- waiting,
- deadlines,
- response time,
- duration of interaction.

Cultures differ in how they understand:

- punctuality,
- scheduling,
- deadlines,
- time pressure.

17. Colour- Colour can communicate meaning through associations and cultural conventions. The reading discusses how colour can influence perceptions and consumer responses.

Example- A company may use a particular colour consistently in its branding to evoke a desired association.

18. Smell- Smell can function as a non-verbal communication cue. perception of people,

- perception of environments,
- consumer experience,
- associations with products.

Example: A particular scent in a retail environment may be deliberately used to create a particular atmosphere.

19. Taste- Food preferences and tastes can communicate or reflect:

- cultural identity,

- social practices,
- preferences,
- group membership.

20. Sound

- background noise,
- music,
- amplification,
- environmental sound,
- vocal characteristics.

Example: Music in a retail store can influence the atmosphere perceived by customers.

21. Silence- Possible functions include:

21.1 Providing Thinking Time

21.2 Hurting

21.3 Isolating Oneself

21.4 Preventing Communication

21.5 Communicating Agreement

21.6 Communicating Rejection

21.7 Communicating Nothing

22. Non-Verbal Communication and the Communication Environment

The environment itself communicates.

- office design,
- seating,
- furniture,
- physical distance,
- lighting,

Key Idea: Communication is influenced not only by **what people do**, but also by **where the interaction takes place**.

1. Listening: Core Idea

Listening ≠ Hearing

Hearing is the **mechanical**/automatic reception of sound and requires relatively little physical or mental effort. **Listening** is a concentrated process requiring active **physical and mental effort** to understand and interpret a message.

2. Mindless vs. Mindful Listening

Mindless Listening

Low-level information processing. It can be acceptable when the information is routine or low-stakes; the listener does not need to devote intense attention.

Mindful Listening

Careful and thoughtful attention to messages. The listener deliberately focuses on the speaker, monitors understanding, and avoids letting distractions or automatic reactions take over.

3. Conversational Rules and Turn-Taking

Conversational Rules

Languages exhibit common properties and are built around organizational principles that allow an orderly exchange of speech. Conversation therefore has implicit rules governing who speaks, when they speak, and how turns are exchanged.

Turn

The period of time during which a speaker has the floor.

Example: In a team discussion, A explains a proposal while B waits; A's speaking period is A's turn.

Keywords: turn, speaker, floor, turn-taking

Turn Construction Unit (TCU)

A unit of speech that can potentially constitute one complete turn; a sentence or phrase can function as a TCU. **Example:** A complete question such as 'When can we submit this?' can form one TCU.

Projectability

TCUs have the feature of projectability: listeners can often anticipate when a current speech unit is approaching completion and therefore when a transition to another speaker may occur.

Example: As a speaker completes a clear question, another participant can anticipate that a response opportunity is about to open.

Formal vs. Informal Speech-Exchange Systems

In formal settings, turn content, turn length, and turn order may be fixed or predetermined by the organization. In informal conversation, these are generally not fixed in advance and are negotiated by speakers.

Overlap / Simultaneous Speech

Conversation can involve speakers producing speech simultaneously. The class examples illustrate that overlap does not automatically mean communication has failed; it is part of naturally occurring turn-taking.

4. Hierarchy of Listening

1. Not Listening At All

2. Listening, Waiting to Speak

3. Listening, Waiting to Disagree

4. Listening to Understand

5. Listening to Create Shared Meanings

5. Problematic Listening Behaviours

Not Paying Attention

Pseudo Listening

The listener appears to listen but is not genuinely processing the message.

Listening but Not Hearing

The listener is exposed to the words but fails to meaningfully register or understand them.

Rehearsing

The listener mentally prepares what to say next instead of attending to the current message.

Interrupting

Hearing What Is Expected

Preconceptions determine what the listener notices or interprets.

Feeling Defensive

The listener experiences disagreement or criticism as a personal threat, reducing openness.

Example: A manager decides what the employee is going to say before the employee finishes.

Listening for a Point of Disagreement

Attention is directed toward finding something to challenge rather than understanding the whole message.

6. Factors Influencing Listening

Emotions

Emotional states can absorb attention or make certain parts of a message more salient.

Speaker's Communication Style

The speaker's mannerisms, delivery, pace, tone, or style can affect the listener's attention and interpretation.

Message Content

The nature, complexity, importance, and emotional content of the message influence how carefully it is processed.

Perception and Listening

Listeners do not process messages in a vacuum; perception and pre-existing interpretations can shape what they notice and understand.

8. Managerial Listening: Major Barriers

25–75 Problem / Listening–Speaking Differential

People can think much faster than speakers can talk. The resulting unused mental capacity can cause attention to wander. **Example:** During a slow presentation, the listener starts thinking about unrelated tasks.

Motivation

Sustaining the motivation required for continuous listening is difficult. A clear listening goal and perceived value can increase effort. **Example:** A manager listens more carefully when the meeting has a clearly defined decision objective.

Willingness

Willingness is distinct from motivation: it can be lost before listening even begins. The reading expresses this through the LAW of listening: $\text{Listening} = \text{Ability} + \text{Willingness}$.

Example: A manager who has already decided that an employee has nothing useful to say may not genuinely listen.

Internal and External Noise

Internal distractions include physical or psychological discomfort; external noise includes environmental sounds or poor transmission conditions.

Detouring

The listener becomes distracted by a phrase, concept, mannerism, or bias and mentally moves to a different topic. **Example:** A speaker's repeated pen-clicking distracts the listener so much that the listener misses the

Debate

The listener starts planning a rebuttal after disagreeing with the speaker and consequently misses the rest of the message.

Time

Perceived lack of time can cause managers to stop listening, rush the interaction, or form hasty conclusions.

9. Types / Intensity of Listening

Active Listening

The listener needs to process and retain the message without relying on immediate clarification.

Interactive Listening

Used when the manager can verbally interact with the speaker through questions, summaries, or paraphrases. It is common in conversations and meetings.

Casual Listening

Lower-intensity listening used when specific or technical information is not critical. The appropriate intensity depends on the situation and the listener's purpose.

Factual Listening

Used when the objective is to obtain specific information. It is common in business meetings, conferences, and informative presentations.

Empathic Listening

Used when the goal is to understand another person from that person's own internal frame of reference, including thoughts and feelings rather than merely imposing the listener's viewpoint.

Listening Goal

A specific statement of the purpose for listening. Managers should decide whether the situation calls for casual, factual, or empathic listening and adjust the goal as the interaction develops.

10. Techniques for Active Listening

Identify Main and Supporting Points

Organize the Message

Recognize the structure used by the speaker: pros/cons, advantages/disadvantages, similarities/differences, chronology, functional duties, etc.

Summarize the Message

Visualize the Message

Convert information into a mental picture to maintain attention and improve retention.

Mnemonics

Personalize the Message

Relate the message to your own role, responsibilities, experience, or consequences.

Take Notes

Use short keywords and phrases to organize, visualize, and personalize the message.

12. Techniques for Interactive Listening

Paraphrasing & clarification

Open Questions vs Closed Questions

Primary Questions vs Secondary Questions / Probes

Follow the primary question and seek deeper, more specific information through clarification or elaboration.

Neutral Questions

Seek information without attempting to lead the speaker toward a preferred answer.

Directed / Leading Questions

Lead the speaker toward a response desired by the questioner. They may be useful for confirmation or clarification on a specific point, but can constrain the response.

13. Listening Styles

Questioning

Questions can clarify meanings, encourage elaboration, encourage discovery, and gather facts/details. However, questions can become toxic when they function as traps, condescending remarks, or sarcastic statements.

Silent Listening

Silence can be used either as avoidance or as support. Effective silent listening still requires active attention and appropriate nonverbal gestures.

Paraphrasing

Restate the speaker's meaning in your own words to confirm that both parties are on the same page.

Supporting

Supportive responses can include offering help, praise, agreement, diversion, and minimizing. Their usefulness depends on the situation; minimizing can be inappropriate when it dismisses genuine concerns.

Example: Offer: 'Do you want me to help with the client call?'

Keywords: supporting, help, praise, agreement, diversion, minimizing

Empathizing

Goes beyond paraphrasing by identifying with the other person's perceptions and feelings.

Analyzing

Helps others see alternative meanings or interpretations of a situation. Analysis should be offered tentatively, have a reasonable chance of being correct, and be used when the person is receptive and the motive is to help.

Example: It sounds like the missed deadline may have been less about effort and more about unclear priorities- does that fit?

Judgemental Style

Begins assigning blame rather than helping the person examine the situation.

14. Listening to Informal Communication

Grapevine

Informal organizational communication can carry important information and rumors.

Example: Employees repeatedly discuss possible restructuring before any formal announcement; the manager pays attention to what concerns employees.

Rumors

Rumors tend to emerge when information is both ambiguous and interesting.

Leveling

As information passes through the grapevine, details and qualifications may be dropped and the context simplified.

Sharpening

Vivid, dramatic, or entertaining details become emphasized as a story is retold.

Assimilating

People modify or adjust information to fit their personal needs, interests, or interpretations.

15. Listening to the Total Environment

Three Dimensions of a Message

Managers should listen across three dimensions: formal ↔ informal, verbal ↔ nonverbal, and obvious ↔ hidden. Effective managerial listening therefore goes beyond literal words.

16. Developing a Listening Climate

Listening Climate

A receptive climate encourages people to communicate.

Micro Listening Climate

The one-on-one listening environment. The manager should give undivided attention, avoid interrupting or finishing sentences, and use appropriate nonverbal behaviours.

Macro Listening Climate

Physical availability, informal interactions, huddles, reduced status barriers, and a genuine open-door environment can promote listening.

Example: A manager regularly visits the team area and holds informal huddles so employees can raise issues easily.

Keywords: macro climate, organizational environment, approachability, open-door policy, huddles, availability

Cultural Differences in Listening

Listening behaviours and expectations can differ across cultures. Differences may occur in use of silence, body language, eye contact, interruptions, formality, and expectations about how people participate in presentations or conversations.

GIVING & RECEIVING FEEDBACK

1. What is Feedback?

Purpose: Enable the recipient to become more effective and elevate performance, helping create conditions in which others can excel.

Internalization: More likely when the giver's intention is developmental AND the receiver believes the giver has that intention.

Core principle: Feedback should focus on observable behaviour, its impact, and what can be learned/changed.

2. The Basic Feedback Formula

FORMAT: “When you do [BEHAVIOUR], it had/has [IMPACT] on [ME/GROUP/OTHERS]...”

Think: BEHAVIOUR → IMPACT → DISCUSSION / DEVELOPMENT

Avoid: Global labels (“always”, “never”), personality judgments, vague criticism.

Use: A specific incident + observable action + concrete impact.

3. Four Underlying Skills

Skill	What it requires
Observation	Pay careful attention to behaviour.
Analysis	Trace the connection between behaviour and impact.
Interpersonal interaction	Deliver feedback in a way that can be heard.
Self-management	Be aware of how giving feedback affects your own emotional state.

4. Effective Feedback — 3 Rules

- **Relevant** — focus on performance characteristics that actually matter.
- No surprises — discuss deficiencies in regular informal/1:1 conversations, not only at formal reviews.
- **Engaged** — the giver should be actively involved and convey the importance of the task.
- Also: choose an appropriate/private **setting**; be considerate; be **specific** and accurate; connect behaviour/results to **consequences**.

5. Sequence Matters

Do NOT rely on the Sandwich: Positive → negative → positive.

ASK–TELL–ASK: ASK for self-assessment → TELL the observed behaviour/performance gap → ASK for thoughts on improvement.

BRIDGE: Connect positive PAST behaviour → PRESENT observation → FUTURE expectation.

6. Five Tactics for Negative Feedback

Tactic	Manager as...	Essence
Emotive	Helper	Appeal to self-concept, feelings and being a valued part of the organization.
Evidence	Judge	Use objective evidence, logic and recorded performance information.
Communication	Conversationalist	Focus on delivery, balance and giving the employee space to respond.
Evidence + Communication	Narrator	Combine evidence with future improvement, action plan and training.
Evidence + Emotive	Cheerleader	Identify the issue, then encourage the employee to improve it.

Choice of tactic: The reading links tactic choice to the employee's personality and ability to handle negative feedback. Evidence can reduce emotion for sensitive employees; evidence + communication can provide a forward-looking perspective.

7. Strengths-Based Feedback

Idea: Move beyond weakness-only feedback: identify exceptional performance, skills and talents, explain how strengths contribute to success, then encourage maintaining/improving those behaviours.

- Can support engagement, motivation, job satisfaction and performance.
- Link negative feedback to KNOWLEDGE/SKILLS rather than to TALENT.
- The giver should know the recipient's relevant knowledge, skills and talents.
- FOLLOW UP after feedback.

8. Feedforward

Definition: Future-oriented suggestions intended to create positive behavioural change.

- Focuses on a future that can be changed rather than a past that cannot.
- Usually easier to give/receive positively and less likely to feel like a personal attack.
- Can come from anyone who knows the task; expertise in the person is not essential.
- Aims to help people be right, rather than prove they were wrong.

Important: Feedforward complements rather than completely replaces feedback/performance appraisal; it can be especially useful in day-to-day interactions.

9. Fear of Feedback

Why people avoid it: Fear of criticism, confrontation, reprisal, change, hurt, rejection or uncertainty.

Typical result: Instead of asking what others think, people guess what the boss thinks and avoid the truth.

Maladaptive responses: Procrastination • denial • brooding • jealousy • self-sabotage

Emotion / fear	Possible response	Reframe
Anger	Acting out	"It's up to me to get the feedback I need."
Anxiety	Brooding / avoiding	"Finding out can open up new opportunities."
Confrontation	Denial / procrastination	"Taking initiative puts me in charge."
Reprisal	Denial	"I need to know honestly how I'm doing."
Hurt	Irritability / jealousy	"I can still pay attention even though I feel hurt."
Defensiveness	Acting out	"Being defensive keeps me from hearing the feedback."
Sadness	Withdrawal	"My performance isn't about whether I'm liked."
Change	Denial	"I need to change one mile at a time."

10. Adapting to Feedback — 5 Techniques

Step	What to do
1. Recognize	Name the emotion + maladaptive behaviour instead of reacting automatically.
2. Support	Use trusted people to identify reactions and rehearse difficult conversations.
3. Reframe	Treat criticism as information / an opportunity for growth rather than only as a threat.
4. Break it up	Turn a large change into manageable, measurable chunks; focus on 1–2 behaviours at a time.
5. Incentivize	Reward meaningful adaptive steps so the process is not entirely negative.

11. Getting the Feedback You Need — 4 Steps

Step	Action
1. Self-assessment	Identify important job elements; recall informal feedback from coworkers, subordinates and customers — including body language, facial expressions and silences.
2. External feedback	Ask a few trusted colleagues first; then directly ask the boss. This is different from broad 360° feedback.
3. Absorb	Stay physically/emotionally neutral; listen for content, tone and body language. Do not immediately react.
4. Act	Convert the information into conclusions, priorities and an action plan; follow through.

COMMUNICATING WITHIN TEAMS

1. Why Team Communication Matters

Core idea: "Talk" is not merely information exchange: it reflects people's thoughts/feelings, creates thoughts/feelings in listeners, and can enhance or inhibit problem solving, relationship development and learning.

Managerial question: Shift from "What do I want to say?" to "What do I want to accomplish?"

Trust & identity: Specific words can reveal who feels included/excluded and whether people trust management/team members. Example: "Somebody ought to tell Management..." signals distance from management.

2. Common Problematic Communication Patterns

Pattern	What it looks like	Risk
Emotion	Anger, exasperation	Escalates rather than solves the issue
Person vs content	Sarcasm, mockery	Attacks the speaker instead of engaging the idea
Dialectic	Saying vs doing	Mismatch undermines credibility
Mindsets/goals	Different assumptions or objectives	People argue past each other
Certainty	"That will never work!"	Closes exploration and alternatives
Provisionalism	"My guess is that you'll run into problems..."	Leaves room for inquiry and response

3. Language-in-Use

Type	Meaning	Example
Affective	Emotion expressed to evoke similar emotion in others	"It would be cowardly to back out now."
Polarizing	Sweeping generalizations that close dialogue	"This is the only way..."
Figurative	Simile, metaphor, personification	"They are like vultures..."
Language of logic	Grounds + claims + assumptions	"Based on X, we claim Y..."
High/low power language	Hedging, hesitation, self-assurance, dominance	"I think..." vs "This will never work."

4. Face Needs & Facework

Face: The social image/needs a person wants maintained in interaction; PPT highlights needs such as approval, admiration and control.

FTA: Face-Threatening Act — communication that threatens another's desired face; typically followed by face-saving / affirming acts.

Facework: Efforts to shape how others view us; face can be built, changed or lost through communication.

Face concerns: Efforts to maintain others' face. Face negotiation = efforts to change/negotiate face.

Orientations: Self-face | Other-face | Mutual-face.

Example: Instead of publicly saying "You don't know what you're talking about," preserve face by disagreeing without humiliation.

5. Team Communication Climate

Inquiry: Goal = arrive at the best possible solution TOGETHER; surface relevant information/perspectives; treat others as collaborators; reveal gaps because others may help.

Advocacy: Goal = WIN; strongly present your view and gain agreement; treat others as competitors; hide gaps in the argument.

Attribute	Advocacy	Inquiry
Goal	To win	Best possible solution together
How you play	Present your view strongly; seek agreement	Surface relevant information + perspectives
Underlying rules	Winner gets points; power may get last word	Learning exercise; develop understanding/new possibilities
View of others	Competitors	Collaborators
Gaps in argument	Hide	Reveal; may trigger useful help

6. Interpersonal Dynamics That Damage Teams

- Power distance + lack of psychological safety.
- Self-protection becomes more important than finding the right answer.
- Antagonistic attitude dominates conversations.
- Heated tone; people question others' knowledge, motives and moral stance.
- Polarized views: each side becomes more extreme as discussion continues.
- Abstract/unexplained assertions such as "It is clear, absolutely clear."

8. Confirming Messages

Why: People need to feel valued; confirming messages are particularly important during stress and uncertainty.

Type	Meaning / use	Example
Recognize	Show that the person is seen/heard	"I can see this has been difficult."
Acknowledge	Recognize the issue/experience	"Last year was difficult for the sales team."
Endorse	Affirm the person's contribution/position where appropriate	"Your concern is worth considering."

9. Creating the Right Team Climate — Language Choices

Less constructive	More constructive
Labelling/evaluative: "You need to take your responsibilities more seriously."	Descriptive: "The report was late this week, which affected client satisfaction."
"You are not competent enough."	"I can't use these slides because they do not include the quarterly results."
Control: "Don't even think about doing that."	Problem orientation: "The action proposed may not lead to the results we want."
Context-free control: "Show up by 8:30."	Contextual: "Slides need to be set up by 8:45, so we need to be there by 8:30."
Neutrality/indifference: "We all face problems; move on."	Empathy/recognition: "Last year was a difficult one for the sales team."
Superiority: "When you're in my position, you'll understand."	Equality: "I'd like to hear how it looks to you; then I can tell you how it looks to me."
Certainty: "That will never work."	Provisionalism: "My guess is that you'll run into problems with that approach."

10. Sensemaking Through Questions

Question type	Purpose + examples
Exploratory	Open the story / gather detail: "Tell me more." "Can you describe the situation?" "What happened next?"
Diagnostic	Understand causes/perspectives: "How do you see the problem?" "What do you think caused this?" "Give me an example."
Action alternative	Move toward options: "What have you tried?" "Have you considered...?" "Advantages/disadvantages?"
Direct / confrontative	Challenge or surface an issue: "Define your goals more clearly." "What is keeping you from solving this?"

11. Practical Rule

Before speaking: Ask what outcome you want to accomplish. Choose language that supports inquiry, psychological safety, face needs and sensemaking—not merely expression of your own position.

12. Fundamentals of a Group

Group: A collection of people who interact, have some degree of **interdependence**, and share a **purpose**/identity; the reading distinguishes groups from a mere collection of individuals.

Key group characteristics from the reading: Participants interact; roles and influence develop; membership is identifiable; norms emerge; leadership exists and can be distributed across members.

13. Cohesiveness

Definition: Degree to which group members **identify** with the group and want to remain **part** of it.

Benefits: More positive interaction, stronger **commitment** to group goals, greater **influence** among members, higher **satisfaction**, and often more effective teamwork.

Caution: High cohesion is not automatically good: if the group becomes overly **conformist**, cohesiveness can contribute to **groupthink** and poor decisions.

Example: A project team that feels **strong ownership** may coordinate well; if it stops questioning the dominant view, the same cohesion can become risky.

14. Norms

Definition: Recurring patterns of behaviour/thinking accepted by the group; norms regulate communication and behaviour.

Examples: "Meetings start on time"; "negative criticism is unacceptable"; "discussions end after 10 minutes."

How learned: Observation, trial and error, and social interaction with existing members.

Function: Facilitate acceptable conduct, coordinate expectations and shape participation.

16. Roles in Groups

Role category	Key roles / function
Task roles	Information giver/seeker; elaborator; initiator; administrator — move the group toward its task/decision.
Personal/social roles	Harmonizer (reduces tension); gatekeeper (keeps members involved); sensor (reads group feelings/climate).
Problem roles	Blocker; avoider; recognition seeker; isolator; dominator; free rider; detractor; digresser; socializer — may disrupt or divert group functioning.

17. Conformity & Groupthink

Conformity: **Agreement** with a set of **ideas/rules/principles**; can help coordination but can also suppress independent thought.

Groupthink: Extreme conformity where **maintaining agreement overrides critical evaluation of alternatives**.

Groupthink symptom	What it means
Illusion of invulnerability	Overconfidence; group feels protected from failure.
Closed-mindedness	Discounts outside information or opposing views.
Pressure toward uniformity	Members suppress disagreement and seek consensus.
Other warning signs	Self-censorship, rationalization of weak evidence, pressure on dissenters, belief in group morality.

18. Reducing Groupthink

- Use **constructive dissent** rather than premature consensus.
- Assign a **devil's advocate**: deliberately challenge the prevailing view and expose weaknesses/alternatives.
- Use **dialectical inquiry**: develop competing plans, identify assumptions behind each, challenge those assumptions, then compare evidence.
- Encourage **outside information** and **diverse perspectives**; avoid one-track thinking.
- Separate idea generation from evaluation where useful.

19. Conflict in Groups

Conflict is not automatically dysfunctional: The reading notes that conflict can be **productive** when it tests ideas, exposes weak assumptions and helps determine what is acceptable.

Unproductive conflict: Becomes personal, attacks participants rather than issues, questions motives/morality, or prevents attention to information.

Managerial principle: Keep disagreement focused on ideas, evidence, assumptions and consequences rather than the person.

20. Group Leadership

Core idea: Participation and leadership are interrelated. A leader is not simply the person who speaks most; leadership can emerge through influence and task/relationship contributions.

Approach	Key idea
Trait	Leadership linked to personal qualities/characteristics.
Style	Focus on leader behaviour; commonly considers task vs relationship orientation.
Situational	No single best style; leadership should fit the situation/group.
Contingency / match	Effectiveness depends on fit between leader style and situational demands.
Functional leadership	Leadership functions can be performed by several group members; focus is on duties/responsibilities needed for group success.

21. Situational Leadership — Developmental Progression

Directing: Follower/member needs high guidance and low autonomy.

Coaching: Leader instructs, explains, encourages participation and supports development.

Supporting: Leader provides less direction and more support as members become more capable/confident.

Delegating: Leader turns responsibility/decision-making over to capable members.

Memory: As readiness/maturity increases → guidance generally decreases and autonomy increases.

22. Participation Styles

Style	Core feature
Authoritarian	Leader makes decisions and tells members what to do; useful when urgency/expertise demands centralized direction.
Laissez-faire	Minimal leader involvement; members have substantial autonomy.
Participative	Members contribute to decisions; leader shares decision-making and seeks input.

23. Factors Affecting Group Participation

Approachability: Members perceive the leader as open to ideas/opinions; effective listening and accessibility encourage participation.

Commitment: Commitment to the group/mission, group success, high-intensity effort and alignment with mission/vision supports participation.

MCOMM — Session 8: Negative Messages & Difficult Conversations

Sources: 8.1 Negative Messages (Locker/Kienzler, *Essentials of Business Communication*, Ch. 7)
· 8.2 "Difficult Conversations: How to Address What Matters Most" (Rotman Magazine, interview with Douglas Stone)

PART A — Negative Messages (Reading 8.1)

A1. Goals when delivering bad news

1. **Explain clearly and completely** — reader shouldn't need to follow up to understand.
2. **Project a professional image** — stay calm and polite even if the receiver is hostile.
3. **Convey empathy and sensitivity** — reduce bad feelings without creating legal liability.
4. **Be fair** — show the decision was impartial and rational.
5. **Maintain friendly relations**, especially with customers.

A2. Direct vs. Indirect strategy

	Direct strategy	Indirect strategy
Structure	Bad news → Reasons → Pleasant close	Buffer → Reasons → Bad news → Closing
Use when bad news...	is not damaging / may be overlooked / recipient prefers directness / firmness is required	is personally upsetting / may provoke hostility / threatens the relationship / is unexpected

- **Ethics check:** Indirect ≠ deceptive. The intent must be **compassion**, not **concealment**. Unethical communicators intend to deceive (e.g., misleading claims); a well-motivated indirect message never hides or misrepresents the truth.

A3. The four-part indirect message (Buffer → Reasons → Bad News → Closing)

Buffer (neutral opener, no bad news yet) — options: best news, compliment, appreciation, agreement, relevant facts, understanding, or an apology.

Apologizing — apologize **promptly and sincerely**; accept responsibility (but check with legal/a superior before formally admitting fault); avoid hollow phrasing ("We regret you were inconvenienced").

- *Poor*: "We apologize if anyone was affected."
- *Improved*: "I apologize for the frustration our delay caused you... I began looking into the cause and realized our tracking system must be improved."

Showing empathy — genuinely understand/acknowledge the reader's feelings (e.g., "You have every right to be disappointed").

Reasons — explain clearly if not confidential/legally risky; cite reader benefits if plausible; explain company policy (don't just cite it); use **positive words** (avoid *cannot*, *claim*, *denied*, *failure*, *unfortunately*, *regret*, etc.); show fairness and serious intent.

Cushioning the bad news — techniques to reduce shock:

- Position bad news in the **middle** of a paragraph, not the start/end.
- Use **passive voice to depersonalize** ("Cash refunds are not given" vs. "We don't give refunds").
- Use **subordinate clauses** beginning *although/because/since* to bury the bad news in a dependent clause.
- **Highlight the positive** (say what you can do).
- **Imply the refusal** rather than stating it outright (risk: reader may miss it — make sure it's still clear).
- **Suggest a compromise or alternative.**

A4. Saying "No" across cultures (quick-reference for cross-cultural relevance)

- **British**: straightforward, little softening needed.
- **German**: occasional buffers, but bad news given directly.
- **Latin American**: negative news to a superior often avoided/softened heavily — reporting bad news upward can be seen as disrespectful.
- **Thai**: the word "no" barely exists; refusal is implied very subtly.
- **Many Asian/Latin cultures**: read between the lines — "*We will consider...*" often really means "no."

PART B — Difficult Conversations (Reading 8.2, Douglas Stone)

B1. Every difficult conversation is really **three conversations**

1. **The "What Happened?" conversation** — disagreement over facts, who's right/wrong, whose fault it is.
2. **The Feelings conversation** — what each person feels but often doesn't say.
3. **The Identity conversation** — what the situation means about me (e.g., "Am I a good boss?"). This is why even discussing someone else can feel threatening to *our own* self-image.

B2. Handling feelings

- Don't default to suppressing *or* oversharing — **it depends on purpose.** Workplace feelings (autonomy, inclusion, appreciation, fairness) that go undiscussed will surface anyway — usually as inefficiency.
- People who *can't suppress* feelings usually don't know it — feelings leak through tone/body language regardless. Fix: make your reaction style explicitly **discussable**, not hidden.

B3. Avoiding vs. Raising the issue

- Reframe "confronting" as **raising the issue skillfully**, not attacking.
- We systematically **under-weigh the costs of avoiding** (relationship erosion over time) and **the benefits of raising** an issue — because avoidance gives *immediate* relief while raising it causes *immediate* anxiety.
- Decision test: weigh both short- and long-term costs/benefits before choosing — there's no default answer.

B4. Difficult Conversation → Learning Conversation

	Difficult Conversation (unproductive)	Learning Conversation (productive)
What Happened	"Whose story is right?" (either/or); "This is their fault."	" <u>Why</u> do we see this differently?"; "We each contributed — <u>let's identify how.</u> "
Feelings	"My feelings are their fault; let them have it or stay quiet."	"My feelings say something about me and their actions — <u>I can share without blame.</u> "

	Difficult Conversation (unproductive)	Learning Conversation (productive)
Identity	"They're attacking <u>my identity unfairly!</u> "	"Some of what they say may have painful truth — what am I really afraid of?"

- **The "And Stance"**: you don't have to choose between two competing stories — both can matter simultaneously. Moves the conversation from *certainty* to *curiosity*.
- **Begin from the "Third Story"**: **not your view, not their view, but how a neutral observer would frame** it — as a *difference* in views/priorities, not right vs. wrong. Reframes the goal from "winning" to "how do we manage this difference?"
- **Tools to escape blind spots**: **Role reversal** (imagine *being* the other person) and **the Observer's Insight** (view the exchange as a neutral third party would).
- **Delivering a tough message = "throwing a hand grenade"** — sugar-coating doesn't remove the damage, and withholding it (avoidance) is like holding a live grenade. **First responsibility is clarity**, not managing the other person's reaction or being liked.

B5. Difficult Conversations Checklist (5 steps)

1. **Walk through the three conversations** — sort out what happened (your story vs. theirs), understand your emotions, ground your identity (what's at stake about *you*).
2. **Check your purpose & decide whether to raise it** — what do you hope to accomplish? Is this really an Identity Conversation in disguise?
3. **Start from the Third Story** — describe the gap between the two stories, share your purpose, invite the other person in as a partner.
4. **Explore their story and yours** — listen, ask questions, acknowledge feelings, paraphrase; then share your own view; **reframe** continuously (truth→perceptions, blame→contribution, accusation→feelings).
5. **Problem-solve** — invent options meeting both sides' core interests; apply standards of mutual caretaking; agree how to keep communication open going forward.

MCOMM — Session 9: Persuasive Communication

The Crux of Communication

- We don't **receive** meaning — we **create** it. *Telling ≠ Communicating.*
- People act on their **belief systems**, not pure logic/rationality — this is *why* persuasion ≠ just presenting facts.

Four mistakes that turn persuasion into a failed sales pitch

1. **The hard sell** — stating a fully-formed position upfront gives people something to argue *against* before they've even heard your reasoning.
2. **Refusing to compromise** — you rarely change someone's view without shifting your own a little in return.
3. **Relying only on logic** — good arguments matter, but *credibility, framing, and emotion* decide how they're actually received.
4. **Treating it as one attempt** — acceptance usually takes several rounds of listening, adjusting, and returning to the table.

The four-step persuasion process

Order matters — *nobody weighs your evidence until they've decided you're worth listening to.*

Step	What it means
1. Credibility	Earned via <u>expertise and relationships</u> . Most people overrate their own credibility.
2. Common ground	Frame the proposal around what the <i>audience</i> gains. No shared benefit → change the proposal, not just the pitch.
3. Evidence	<u>Figures alone are forgettable</u> — <u>back them with examples, stories, analogies.</u>
4. Emotional connection	Show you <u>believe</u> the argument yourself; <u>match its intensity</u> to the room's mood.

Aristotle's Triad (Class Concepts — underlies Steps 1, 3 & 4 above)

- **Ethos** (**Credibility**) — sharing values, background, expertise to build trust.

- **Logos** (**Evidence**) — logical order, data, factual information.
- **Pathos** (**Emotional connection**) — vivid language, shared experience, evoked emotion.

Applied example — "How did Lindsey gain trust?" (case discussed in class):

- *Ethos*: created dissonance in the jury's mind; recognized & addressed audience biases ("All lawyers are crooks!"); signalled she was honest and guileless.
- *Pathos*: recognized grief, tapped anger, leveraged existing biases, used the right analogies/visuals, tonality & facial expression, and **liking** ("we like those who like us" — one of the *least-used* but powerful levers).
- *Logos*: supported claims with statistics/authoritative bodies; addressed gaps in "warrants"/assumptions; made the opposition look unreasonable; used **two-sided counter-arguments**.

Opinions, Attitudes & Beliefs — aim where movement is actually possible

Beliefs form early rarely move; opinions sit at the edge and shift with new evidence. Positions held for emotional reasons rarely give way to a better argument — so match your tactic to what you're up against:

Audience holds	Tactic	Goal
Opinions (already agree with you)	Reinforce	Strengthen existing supporters — they go on to carry the argument to others.
Attitudes (undecided)	Crystallise	Give the undecided a position to hold <i>before</i> the opposing view reaches them.
Beliefs (committed opponents)	Neutralise	Realistic aim is to <i>limit their reach</i> , not convert them.

Cialdini's Six Principles of Influence

Grouped by what each one works on:

Works on...	Principle	Mechanism
How we relate to you	Liking	We agree more readily with people we like or resemble.

Works on...	Principle	Mechanism
Who else is doing it	Social proof	We look to people like us before deciding.
How we protect a choice	Consistency	A public, voluntary commitment is hard to walk back.
—	Reciprocity	People repay what they receive (help, time, concessions).
—	Authority	We defer to expertise — our own, or one we bring in.
—	Scarcity	What's limited feels more valuable. Caution: faking scarcity destroys credibility once discovered.

Supplementary influence tactics (Class Concepts)

- **Loss aversion**: frame around what the other party *stands to lose* by not accepting (or the *risks of the alternative*), rather than what they'd gain by accepting.
- **Reciprocity** (elaborated): unilateral concessions create a felt need to reciprocate; concessions build goodwill and satisfy the need to be seen as "fair" and "good" — connects to social proof.
- **Anchoring**: people rely heavily on the *first* number/data point they receive; later information gets interpreted relative to that initial anchor.
- **Consistency & commitment** (elaborated): people want to be seen as consistent with past actions/statements — especially commitments made **publicly and voluntarily**.

One-sided vs. Two-sided arguments

Use a one-sided argument when..	Use a two-sided argument when..
Audience already agrees — you just want to strengthen the view	Audience starts out disagreeing with you
They know very little about the topic	They already know the topic / will hear the opposing case elsewhere
They're unlikely to hear the opposing case afterward	You want the attitude change to last
They're not closely involved with the issue	—

Rule of thumb: if the audience is likely to hear the opposing case anyway, address it yourself first. **Hard limit:** misrepresenting facts will be found out — and credibility, once lost, is the hardest thing to rebuild.

Planning Persuasion by resistance level:

Audience Mindset	Persuader's <u>Goal</u>	Core Tactic	Practical Example
<u>Strongly Opposed</u>	Create uncertainty	Use cognitive dissonance ; target core assumptions.	Corporate Restructure: Instead of arguing that a new system is better, ask, <i>"How much time does our current system lose to daily crashes?"</i> to make them question their reliance on it.
<u>Opposed</u>	Reduce resistance	Use cognitive dissonance + introduce new data .	Budget Cuts: Acknowledge their frustration, then show data proving that cutting travel budgets now directly prevents layoffs later.
<u>Neutral / Unsure</u>	Change attitude	Use a two-sided counter-argument .	Software Upgrade: <i>"While the new interface has a learning curve, it automates 80% of our manual reporting, saving you hours every week."</i>
<u>Favorable / Supportive</u>	Amplify attitude	Use a one-sided message .	Charity Drive: <i>"Your donations last year saved 500 animals. Let's double our impact this year by hitting our new goal."</i>

Every persuasive case must do three things — Head, Heart, Hands

	Head	Heart	Hands
Delivers	Evidence they respect	Emotion that matches the room	A clear, immediate action
How	Framed around what <i>they</i> stand to gain, not what <i>you</i> want	Enough feeling to move people — not enough to alarm them	Say exactly what you want done; make it easy to do now

↓
logical

↓
Emotional

↘ practical / actionable

MCOMM — Session 10: Cross-Cultural / Intercultural Communication

Core Cultural Frameworks

A. **Hofstede's** Dimensions (combines Munter + Ch.12 + Class Concepts)

Dimension	Low end	High end	Example countries
Power distance	Egalitarian , question authority, first names, power used for legitimate ends only	Autocratic , don't challenge authority, respect by title/surname	Low: Israel, Denmark, Austria, USA · High: Philippines, Venezuela, Mexico
Uncertainty avoidance	High tolerance for ambiguity , few rules	Low tolerance; extensive rules/rituals to create certainty ; resistant to change	Low: Singapore, HK, Denmark, USA · High: Japan, Portugal, Greece, Germany
Individualism / Collectivism	"I" identity , individual decisions, in-value standards apply to everyone	"We" identity , group loyalty/security, in-group vs. out-group standards differ	Individualist: USA (highest), Australia, UK · Collectivist: Venezuela, Colombia, Peru, Saudi Arabia
Masculinity / Femininity	Feminine = quality of life, caring , relationships	Masculine = assertiveness, achievement , material wealth	Masculine: Japan, Austria, Switzerland, Italy · Feminine: Sweden, Norway, Netherlands, Denmark
Monochronic / Polychronic time	Monochronic = one thing at a time , punctuality, schedules followed strictly, "time is money"	Polychronic = multiple things in parallel , relative/relaxed attitude to time, relationships > schedule	Mono: Germany, USA, Switzerland · Poly: Spain, Latin America, most Asian & African cultures

Dimension	Low end	High end	Example countries
High-context / Low-context (Edward Hall)	Low context = explicit words carry meaning; efficiency valued; written/legalistic agreements	High context = meaning lives in situation/relationship/ nonverbal cues; oral agreements/trust valued	Low: German, Swiss, Scandinavian, North American · High: Japanese, Arab, Chinese, Vietnamese, Korean

B. Kluckhohn & Strodtbeck — Cultural Values System (Munter, Fig. 1)

Attitude toward	Range	Communication implication
Nature	Submit to nature (fate/God) ↔ Harmony with nature ↔ Mastery over nature	Shapes realistic communication objectives
Time	Past tradition ↔ Present moment ↔ Future goals	Shapes realistic communication objectives
Social relations	By rank/class (authoritarian) ↔ By group ↔ By individual	Shapes audience selection
Activity	Being (minimize work) ↔ Inner development ↔ Doing (maximize work)	Shapes audience motivation
Humanity	Basically evil (control needed) ↔ Mixed ↔ Basically good (trust)	Shapes audience motivation

- Example: Saudi Arabia (external control/past-oriented) vs. USA (internal control/"can-do" future-oriented) sit at opposite poles.
- **Locus of control**: internal (people control events — US) vs. external (events predetermined/fate — Islamic cultures' *Insha'allah*, Filipino *bahala na*).

C. Universalists vs. Particularists (Class Concepts, Trompenaars-based)

Universalists	Particularists
Common rules for everyone ; trust in systems	Obligations to specific people/relationships come first; trust in networks
Standardisation , fairness, objective measurement	Customisation , contextual appropriateness, subjective judgment
"People assigned to tasks"	"Tasks assigned to people"

3. Munters 7 Issues for Effective Managerial Communication Across Cultures

1. **Setting communication objectives** — ask: *Is my objective realistic given the culture's locus of control? Is my timeframe realistic given the culture's concept of time?*
2. **Choosing a communication style** — four styles, situational: **Tell** (inform, no audience input needed) · **Sell** (persuade, some involvement) · **Consult** (interact, need their input) · **Join** (collaborate/brainstorm).
 Tell/Sell → more natural in high-power-distance/individualist cultures;
 Consult/Join → more natural in low-power-distance/collectivist cultures.
3. **Assessing & enhancing credibility** — 5 credibility factors, weighted differently by culture:
 - **Rank credibility** (matters more in **high-power-distance cultures** — establish rank via family status in South America, village chiefs in Samoa, schooling in France)
 - **Goodwill credibility** (personal trust — critical in **high-context cultures**; **socialize before business**)
 - **Expertise credibility** (matters more in **low-context cultures** — Germany, Switzerland, Scandinavia)
 - **Image credibility** (age valued in Korea/Africa, **upper-class valued** in UK/India, male valued in Iran)
 - **Shared values credibility** (find **common ground** beyond typical American appeals like "bottom line")
4. **Selecting & motivating audiences** — who is primary/secondary audience differs by culture (tribe in Africa, family in South America, class in Egypt); tailor appeals to uncertainty avoidance (security appeals in Japan/Greece vs. risk/challenge appeals in Singapore/Denmark) and masculinity (material rewards in Austria/Switzerland vs. quality-of-life in Sweden/Norway). **"Achievement" as a concept barely translates outside English** — reserve classic American appeals (wealth, achievement) for masculine + low-uncertainty-avoidance cultures.
5. **Setting a message strategy** — **direct** structure favoured by **low-context** cultures; **indirect** (build-up) favoured by **high-context** cultures, where bluntness risks **loss of face**. High-

context cultures often prefer oral agreements (a written contract can signal distrust — e.g., the Ford–Ferrari deal falling through after lawyers arrived with paperwork).

Message formats (paper size, memo length, presentation style) also vary.

6. **Overcoming language difficulties** — semantics (untranslatable words: Korean *kibun*, Finnish *sisu*), connotation (*mañana* ≠ literally "tomorrow"; Japanese *hai* can mean "I'm listening," not "I agree"), tone (formal/informal, direct/indirect), and perception itself differing by language. If not fluent: use simple English or a well-briefed interpreter, pausing after short segments.
7. **Using nonverbal behaviors** — **65–90% of communication is nonverbal** (Knapp). Covers body language, personal space (Americans: 0–18in intimate, 18in–4ft personal, 4–12ft social, 12ft+ public; Latin Americans/Arabs stand much closer; British prefer more distance), touch frequency (San Juan 180 touches/hr vs. London 0/hr in one study), and greeting norms (namaste, wai, nop, Japanese bows, abrazo).

4. Nonverbal & Etiquette Specifics (Ch. 12 — high-yield examples)

- **Greetings**: handshake pressure varies (firm ≠ universal positive); Japanese may bow *and* shake hands; business cards in Japan are handed/received with both hands, studied carefully, never scribbled on.
- **Gestures** (danger zone): "OK" sign is vulgar in Brazil/Russia; thumbs-up is an insult in Australia; nodding head = "no" in Bulgaria/Yugoslavia/Iran/Sri Lanka; pointing with index finger is rude in Sudan/Venezuela/Sri Lanka.
- **Touch**: never touch the head in Buddhist cultures/Thailand/China (sacred); never use the left hand in Muslim cultures; never show the sole of your shoe in Muslim cultures.
- **Gifts**: number 4 = bad luck (Japan); the color white or purple flowers signal death/funerals in Japan; tipping is an insult in China; company-logo gifts can be read as "cheap," not thoughtful.
- **Food**: refusing a host's offering (even sheep's eyes, shark-fin soup) is a serious insult in many cultures.

5. What makes a "Good Intercultural Communicator" (Ch. 12)

Avoid **ethnocentrism** (seeing your own culture as superior). Be:

- **Non-defensive** about your homeland's flaws
- **Curious and brave** about other places/people
- **Empathic, understanding, non-judgmental**
- **Patient and industrious** — comfortable with ambiguity, resourceful when plans change
- **Genuinely personable** — real interest/respect for people cannot be faked

6. Saying "No" Across Cultures (Ch. 12 — ties to Session 8's bad-news strategy)

Culture	Pattern
British	Straightforward, little softening
German	Occasional buffers, but direct
Latin American	Reluctant to report bad news upward — seen as disrespectful
Thai	"No" barely exists as a word — refusal is extremely subtle
Many Asian/Latin cultures	Read between the lines: <i>"We will consider..."</i> often really means <i>"not a chance"</i>